

WINDOW DRESSING

Indian analysts dismiss Pakistan's action to arrest LeT members as purely symbolic, a charade to buy time.

DAUR-E-AAM: The basic 21-day training camp. Recruits are given training sessions on weapons like the AK-47, 9 mm pistol, light machine gun and grenade handling.

DAUR-E-KHAS: The specialised three-month training where recruits are trained to assemble assault rifles, use maps, GPS and guerilla action. They are taught raids, ambushes, how to hide and survive.

BAITUL RIZWAN: Specialised training where river crossing and handling explosives are taught.

DAUR-E-RIBAT: Intelligence training where trade crafts like propaganda, collecting intelligence, agent handling and sabotage are taught.

FIDAYEEN TRAINING: Only one person from a batch of around 200 volunteers opts to become a suicide attacker who is then given a number of courses to make him physically and mentally tough.



the jihad. Invariably, they end up finding more recruits for their deadly cause. Analysts believe the LeT has a force of over 20,000 fighters within Pakistan and at least 1,000 activists within J&K. Yet, soon after 9/11 the LeT had already begun looking beyond the Valley. In 2005, Saeed determined the places where graduates of an LeT camp in Pakistan should be sent to fight, and personally organised the infiltration of militants into Iraq during a trip to Saudi Arabia. That year, he also arranged for an LeT operative to be sent to Europe as LeT's European fundraising coordinator. US intelligence began tracking Lashkar-e-Toiba soon after Saeed set up a terrorist training camp in Pakistan in 2006 to prepare militants to fight against NATO-led coalition forces in Afghanistan.

Mumbai police believe that at least 20 other attackers were specially trained by the LeT and could be used in future operations like Mumbai and possibly elsewhere in the world as well.

Fidayeen attackers like the 10 who struck Mumbai were handpicked by the Lashkar

brass, who look for qualities like high motivation, fitness and a ruthless streak, and trained separately at a small Lashkar camp in Sialkot. At the training camp, recruits are kept isolated for nearly two months and shown video footage and photographs of their targets and are given detailed briefings of the target areas.

Lashkar has been secretive and selective in inducting its cadres into India, tasking them for specific perform-and-perish operations. Interrogation reports reveal that the recent infiltration of LeT ultras into the Kashmir Valley had been with the Pakistani Army's knowledge. After lying low for the past few years, Saeed resurfaced early this year issuing a raft of statements in support of Kashmiri separatist leaders. On August 26, he announced the JUD would launch a countrywide campaign to make people aware of the 'plight of Kashmiris'. Not surprisingly, he slammed the Pakistani government for cracking on the JUD-LeT camps in POK in the wake of the American and Indian pressure after the Mumbai attacks, terming it as "an unwarranted action at the behest of India and the US".

Lashkar recruitment may have dipped in recent years, as may have its ability to attract motivated cadre. Kasab says he joined the LeT out of economic need rather than religious fervour. But with the flow of recruits still on, India may have to go after the source in Pakistan.

Short of potentially escalatory military options like air and ground strikes against the camps, India has very limited options against the terror outfit. Experts like Ajai Sahni of the Centre for Conflict Studies call for secret action against the LeT camps and leadership inside Pakistan. "Short of covert capabilities and targeted covert options, nothing else will work against them," says Sahni. A capability that I.K. Gujral dismantled as prime minister over a decade ago will take over a year to rebuild. Faced with mounting international pressure, Pakistan recently moved against the LeT, arresting Lakhvi but refusing to hand him over to India. These, however, are measures that the Indian intelligence fraternity term 'window dressing' designed to buy the Pakistan military and ISI, time and manoeuvring space. The LeT will be the unintentional beneficiary of both.